

Word family: old / older / oldest / old age / old-fashioned / old-school / old-time / olden

Base word: old

Comparative: older

Superlative: oldest

Related forms / useful extensions: old age, old-fashioned, old-school, old-time, olden

Part of speech: mainly adjective (形容詞) / occasional noun-like use in fixed structures (固定結構中的名詞化用法)

Your sentence:

“An old person I know well is my grandmother on my mother's side.”

Your passage later also contains:

“To me she is a bit like an old tree.”

So the passage itself gives us two related but contextually different applications of old.

Meaning in this passage

In:

“An old person I know well is my grandmother...”

old means having lived for many years and being in the later stage of life.

Here, your grandmother is in her late seventies, so old describes her advanced age.

繁體中文：年紀已經較大、處於人生較後階段的；年長的／年老的

中文翻譯：

“An old person I know well is my grandmother on my mother's side.”

「我很熟悉的一位年長人士／老人家是我媽媽那邊的外婆。」

Here:

old person = 年紀較大、已進入人生較後階段的人

A small usage note is important here:

old person is grammatically correct, but depending on context, English speakers often prefer more neutral expressions such as:

older person

older adult

elderly person

especially when speaking directly about someone's age.

1. old + person (人) — 年長的；年老的

Meaning: Having lived for many years and being in a later stage of life.

Practice 1 — Original

“An old person I know well is my grandmother on my mother's side.”

「我很熟悉的一位年長人士是我媽媽那邊的外婆。」

Practice 2

“The old man still walks to the market every morning.”

「那位年長的男子／老人家每天早上仍然步行到市場。」

Practice 3

“Many older people prefer to remain independent for as long as possible.”

「很多年長人士都希望盡可能長時間保持獨立生活。」

old = 已經活了很多年、處於人生較後階段的

2. old + animal/tree/living thing (動物／樹木／生物) — 生長／存活了很多年的；年老的

This is the sense used later in your passage:

“She is a bit like an old tree.”

The same general age concept applies to living things other than humans.

Practice 4 — From your passage

“To me she is a bit like an old tree.”

「對我來說，她有點像一棵生長了很多年的老樹。」

Practice 5

“An old oak tree stands in the centre of the village.”

「村子中央有一棵生長了很多年的老橡樹。」

old tree/animal = 已經生長或存活了很長時間的生物

This remains closely related to #1 rather than representing a completely unrelated lexical meaning.

3. old + object/building (物件／建築物) — 存在／使用了很久的；舊的

For objects, old normally refers to how long something has existed or been used rather than biological age.

Practice 6

“They live in an old house near the river.”

「他們住在河邊一間已有很多年歷史的舊房子。」

Practice 7

“My laptop is getting old, so I may replace it soon.”

「我的手提電腦已經用了很多年、開始老舊了，所以我可能很快會更換它。」

old object/building = 已存在或被使用多年，因此年代較久的

4. old = from a long time ago (年代久遠) — 古老的；很久以前的

Here, the emphasis is not simply that an object has physically aged, but that it belongs to an earlier period of history.

Practice 8

“They discovered an old manuscript in the library.”

「他們在圖書館發現了一份年代久遠的手稿。」

Practice 9

“The museum contains many old photographs of the city.”

「博物館收藏了很多這座城市的舊時照片／年代久遠的照片。」

old = 來自較久以前的年代或歷史時期

5. old = previous / former (以前的) — 從前的；舊有的

This is a very important meaning.

Old can identify something connected with an earlier stage of someone's life or situation, even if the thing itself is not physically ancient.

Practice 10

“I met some colleagues from my old job.”

「我遇到了一些以前那份工作的同事。」

Practice 11

“She went back to visit her old school.”

「她回去探訪自己的母校／以前就讀的學校。」

old job/school/address/etc. = 某人以前擁有、使用、任職或身處的，而不是現在的

This does not necessarily mean:

very ancient ❌

For example:

my old apartment

can simply mean:

我以前住的那個單位

even if the building is brand new.

6. old + friend/classmate/neighbour(長期認識的人) — 相識已久的

Another extremely useful sense.

An old friend does not necessarily mean an elderly friend.

It usually means:

someone you have known for a long time.

Practice 12

"I had dinner with an old friend from university."

「我跟一位認識多年的大學舊友吃晚飯。」

Practice 13

"She ran into an old classmate at the station."

「她在車站偶遇一位以前的同學／相識多年的舊同學。」

old friend = 認識了很長時間的朋友, 而不一定是年紀很大的朋友

This distinction is especially important for learners.

7. number + years/months/etc. + old(年齡) —歲

A major grammatical construction.

Practice 14

"Her grandmother is seventy-eight years old."

「她的外婆七十八歲。」

Practice 15

"The baby is only six months old."

「那個嬰兒只有六個月大。」

number + time unit + old = 表示人、動物或事物自出生／產生以來已有多少時間

For objects:

"The building is 200 years old."

= 「這棟建築已有二百年歷史。」

8. old enough to + verb(年齡／成熟程度) — 已經大到可以.....

This is a highly useful grammatical extension.

Practice 16

"She is old enough to travel by herself."

「她已經大到可以自己旅行了。」

Practice 17

"You are old enough to make your own decisions."

「你已經到了可以自己作決定的年紀。」

old enough to do something = 年齡或成熟程度已達到足以進行某事的水平

Notice that old here does not mean elderly.

A fifteen-year-old can be:

old enough to do something

without being "old" in the elderly sense.

9. too old for/to + noun/verb — 年紀太大, 不適合／不能.....

Practice 18

"He thinks he is too old to learn another language."

「他覺得自己年紀太大, 已不適合學另一種語言。」

Practice 19

“She says she is too old for all-night parties now.”

「她說自己現在年紀已經不適合通宵派對了。」

too old to/for = 年齡超出某項活動被認為合適或可行的範圍

This is contextual and sometimes subjective rather than an objective physical limitation.

10. old = no longer new / current (不再是新的／最新的) — 舊的; 舊版本的

Here old contrasts with new/current/latest.

Practice 20

“Delete the old version of the document.”

「把文件的舊版本刪除。」

Practice 21

“The company replaced its old system with a newer one.”

「公司以較新的系統取代了舊系統。」

old version/system/model = 已被較新的版本、系統或型號取代的

This meaning is very common in technology.

11. old = no longer fresh (食物／材料等) — 放久了的; 不新鮮的

With certain things, old can suggest deterioration caused by time.

Practice 22

“The bread tastes old.”

「這些麵包吃起來不新鮮／像放了很久。」

Practice 23

“Throw away any old food in the fridge.”

「把雪櫃裡那些放太久、不新鮮的食物丟掉。」

old food/material = 放置時間太長, 以致已不再新鮮或處於最佳狀態

This is more contextual than the basic “existing for a long time” sense.

12. old-fashioned = following styles/ideas from the past (觀念／款式) — 老式的; 過時的

This is an important family extension.

Practice 24

“The hotel has a charming old-fashioned interior.”

「這間酒店有一種很有魅力的復古／老式室內設計。」

Practice 25

“Some people think that view is old-fashioned.”

「有些人認為那種觀念已經過時／守舊。」

old-fashioned = 屬於較早年代的風格、方式或觀念, 在現代可能顯得傳統或過時

The tone can be:

positive → charming, traditional

negative → outdated, behind the times

depending on context.

13. old-school = traditional in style, attitude, or method (傳統派的) — 老派的; 傳統風格的

A common informal extension.

Practice 26

“My grandfather is very old-school about manners.”

「我祖父在禮儀方面十分傳統／老派。」

Practice 27

“The café has an old-school atmosphere.”

「這間咖啡店帶有一種傳統復古的氣氛。」

old-school = 採用較傳統的方法、態度或風格, 而不是現代做法

It can be approving, neutral, or mildly critical.

14. old age = later stage of human life (人生階段) — 老年; 晚年

A common noun expression.

Practice 28

“Regular exercise can improve quality of life in old age.”

「恆常運動可以改善老年時期／晚年的生活質素。」

Practice 29

“She remained active well into old age.”

「她到了晚年仍然十分活躍。」

old age = 人生接近後期、年紀較大的階段

15. the old = older people collectively (集合用法) — 老年人; 長者

This is grammatically possible, but register needs attention.

Practice 30

“Traditional societies often emphasized respect for the old.”

「傳統社會往往強調對長者的尊重。」

Practice 31

“The policy was designed to support both the young and the old.”

「這項政策旨在支援年輕人和年長人士。」

the old = 把年長人士作為一個群體來說

However, in ordinary modern communication, older people / older adults often sounds more natural and person-focused than simply the old.

16. the old days / old times (過去的一段時期) — 從前; 昔日

Practice 32

“He often talks about the old days.”

「他經常談起從前的日子／昔日時光。」

Practice 33

“Things were very different in the old days.”

「從前的情況跟現在很不一樣。」

the old days = 過去某個較早、常帶回憶色彩的時期

It frequently carries nostalgia.

17. good old + person/thing — 熟悉而令人有親切感的; 還是老樣子最可靠

This is a common informal expression.

Practice 34

“Nothing beats good old homemade food.”

「還是熟悉可靠的家常菜最好。」

Practice 35

“I spent the evening with good old Tom.”

「我晚上跟老朋友 Tom／那個熟悉親切的 Tom 一起度過。」

good old + noun = 表達熟悉、親切、懷念或喜愛, 有時帶幽默語氣

Here old may contribute more of a feeling of familiarity than literal age.

Important distinction: old vs older

old

directly describes someone or something as having substantial age.

“an old person”

= 「一位年老／年長的人」

older

can simply mean:

more advanced in age than someone/something else

or can be used as a softer description of elderly people.

“an older person”

= 「一位年紀較大的人」

So a person can be:

older than me

without being objectively:

old

Important distinction: old vs elderly

old

is extremely broad and can describe:

people

animals

buildings

objects

ideas

systems

friendships

former situations

elderly

normally describes people who are relatively advanced in age.

an elderly woman

= 一位年長女士

Normally not:

an elderly building ❌

So old has a much broader semantic range.

Important distinction: old person vs old friend

This is especially important.

an old person

= a person who has lived for many years

「年長的人」

an old friend

usually = someone you have known for many years

「老朋友／相識多年的朋友」

It does not normally mean:

a friend who is elderly.

The noun after old changes how the age/familiarity concept is interpreted.

Important distinction: old vs ancient

old

simply means having existed for a relatively long time.

“an old building”

ancient

usually means extremely old, especially belonging to a remote historical period.

“an ancient temple”

「古代寺廟／極古老的寺廟」

So:

ancient is much stronger and more historically marked than old.

Important distinction: old vs old-fashioned

old

describes age, previous status, or long existence.

“an old phone”

= 一部用了很多年的／舊的電話

old-fashioned

describes a style, attitude, design, or method associated with an earlier period.

“an old-fashioned phone”

= 款式／設計很老式的電話

An item can therefore be:

new but old-fashioned

For example, a newly manufactured retro-style radio.

Important distinction: old friend vs former friend

These are almost opposites in an important way.

old friend

usually means:

someone who has been your friend for a long time

「老朋友」

former friend

means:

someone who used to be your friend but is not your friend now

「以前的朋友／已經不是朋友的人」

So:

my old friend

does not normally mean:

my former friend

Family-extension note

Following the curation style in the reference, these are especially useful members and constructions of the old family:

old person = 年長的人

old tree/building/object = 存在很多年的

old friend = 相識多年的朋友

old job/school/home = 以前的工作／學校／住所

years old =歲

old enough to = 年齡／成熟程度足以.....

too old to/for = 年紀太大而不適合.....

old version/system = 已被更新版本取代的舊版本／系統

old age = 老年; 晚年

the old = 年長人士這一群體

old-fashioned = 老式的; 過時的

old-school = 老派的; 傳統風格的

the old days = 昔日; 從前

good old... = 熟悉、親切、令人懷念的.....

As with the reference examples, these should not all be presented as unrelated dictionary meanings of bare old. Several are grammatical patterns, collocations, or useful lexical extensions built around a smaller group of underlying semantic ideas. The reference explicitly treats such extensions separately from core bare-word meanings.

Master comparison

Form / sense MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning

old — person 已活了很多年、處於人生較後階段的; 年長的

old — living thing 已經生長或存活了很長時間的

old — object/building 已存在或使用多年、年代較久的

old — from long ago 來自較久以前年代或歷史時期的

old job/school/home 某人以前擁有、使用或身處的, 而非現在的

old friend 已認識很長時間的朋友

years old 表示人／事物自出生或產生以來已有多少時間

old enough to 年齡或成熟程度已足以進行某事

too old to/for 年齡超出某項活動適合或可行的範圍

old version/system 已被較新版本或系統取代、不再是目前最新的

old food 放置時間較長, 以致不再新鮮或處於最佳狀態

old-fashioned 屬於較早年代的風格、方式或觀念; 老式／過時

old-school 採用較傳統的態度、方法或風格

old age 人生較後期、年紀較大的階段

the old 作為一個群體來說的年長人士

the old days 過去某段常帶回憶或懷念色彩的時期

good old... 對熟悉的人／事物表達親切、喜愛或懷念

For your original sentence

“An old person I know well is my grandmother on my mother's side.”

The exact meaning is:

old = 已經活了很多年、年紀較大, 處於人生較後階段的

Therefore:

an old person

= 「一位年紀較大／年長的人」

In the context of your grandmother being in her late seventies, old refers straightforwardly to advanced human age.

And your later metaphor:

“She is a bit like an old tree.”

uses the same underlying age concept in a different context:

old tree = 一棵已經生長了很多年、因年代久而令人聯想到穩定、成熟和持久的樹

The metaphorical ideas of stability, wisdom, and shelter come mainly from the comparison with the tree and the surrounding sentence—not from a separate lexical meaning of old itself.